

Sabalenka overpowers Zheng for second Australian Open title

When her parents sent 15-year-old Aryna Sabalenka to the national tennis academy in Minsk in 2014, the coaches thought she was too stupid for the sport.

Her father Sergey, a former ice hockey player, knew better. Aryna recalled, "He told me then that I have everything I needed to achieve this goal — I just had to learn myself better, to learn how to control my emotions, and one day I'd be world number one. It was like our dream."

That dream came true last September when she grabbed the top spot, but it was bittersweet. Sergey, who unexpectedly died in November 2019, did not live to see it.

Her dad had set another goal that she was determined to fulfill — two Grand Slam titles by age 25.

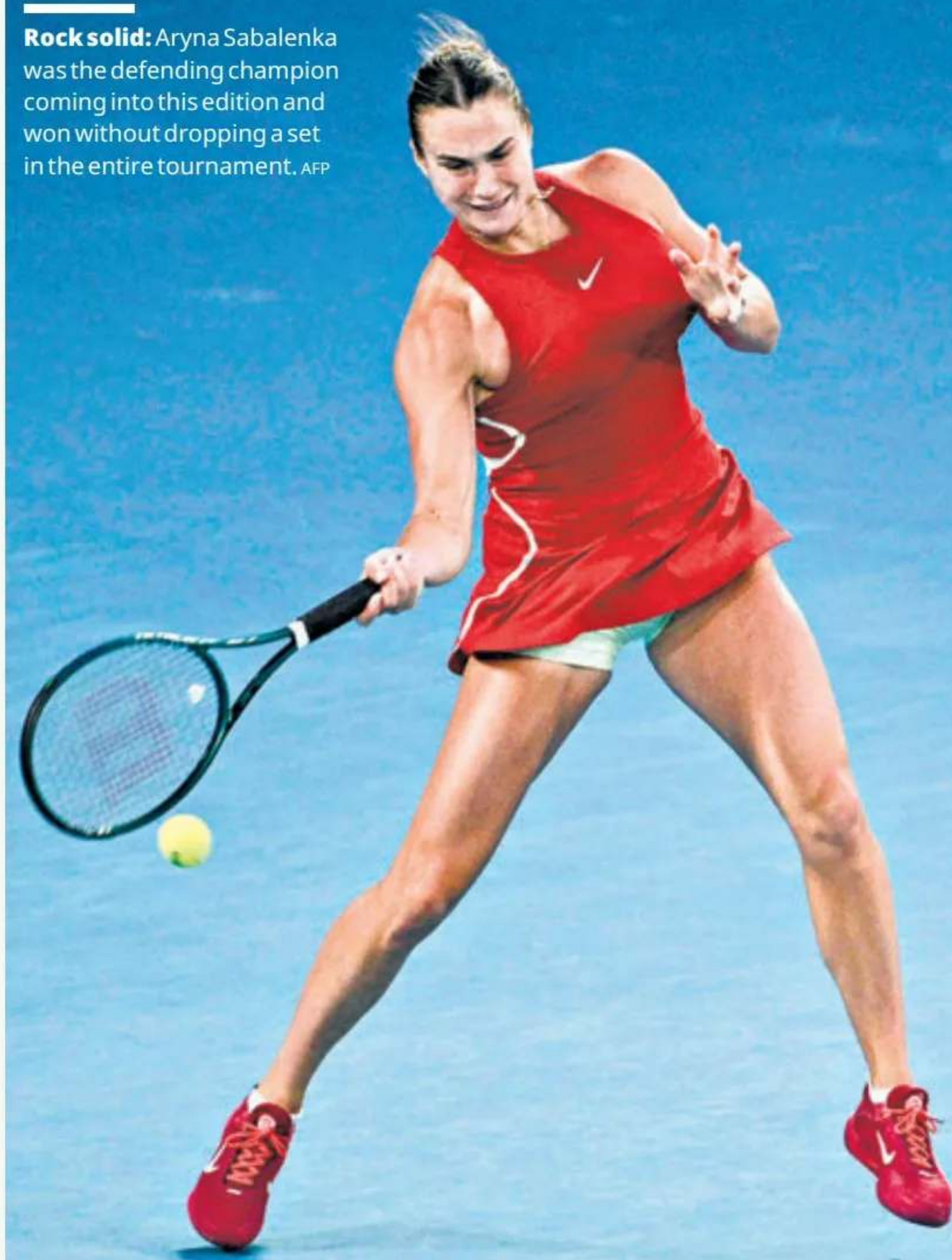
A year ago in Melbourne, Aryna finally exorcised the demons that had plagued her in extremely close, high-stakes matches to win her first Grand Slam crown, overcoming Elena Rybakina 4-6, 6-3, 6-4 in a ferocious, power-hitting final.

Still, doubts persisted about her newfound mental toughness. "Pressure is a privilege," as tennis legend Billie Jean King famously said, but Sabalenka, who turned 25 last May, succumbed to the P word at the next three majors in 2023. Karolina Muchova, a hyper-athletic Czech ranked a misleading No. 43, upset her 7-6, 6-7, 7-5 in the French Open semifinals. Then, at Wimbledon, Tunisian trickster Ons Jabeur bamboozled her with a disruptive blend of power and touch shots, 6-7, 6-4, 6-3, in another disappointing semifinal.

Two months later in New York, Sabalenka overwhelmed five opponents before coming back to outlast red-hot Madison Keys 0-6, 7-6, 7-6. "She broke the curse of the US Open semifinals," *ESPN* analyst Mary Joe Fernandez said, referring to the heartbreaking three-set losses Aryna suffered against heavy underdog Leylah Fernandez in 2021 and Swiatek a year earlier.

The 2023 US Open final demonstrated once again how cruel tennis can treat players — especially

Rock solid: Aryna Sabalenka was the defending champion coming into this edition and won without dropping a set in the entire tournament. *AFP*



the stars. Teen phenom Coco Gauff, buoyed by the fervent Flushing Meadows crowd, absorbed and defused Aryna's power and added topspin for forehand consistency to upset the increasingly error-prone Sabalenka 2-6, 6-3, 6-2 for her first major title.

Nothing motivates a tennis player more than revenge. "I'll follow that son-of-a-b*#@#h to the ends of the earth," Jimmy Connors memorably vowed after Bjorn Borg humiliated him in the 1978 Wimbledon final.

Sabalenka had a score to settle with rising star Gauff in the 2024 Australian Open semifinals. After pummeling No. 9 seeded Barbora

Krejcikova 6-2, 6-3 in the quarterfinals, Aryna said, "I love it. After [the] US Open, I really wanted that revenge. It's always great battles against Coco, with really great fights. I'm happy to play her, and I'm super-excited to play that semifinal match."

Before their eagerly anticipated rematch, former No. 1 Lindsay Davenport, now a *Tennis Channel* analyst, voiced what many wondered: "[At] the last three majors, Sabalenka has really melted down. Does Sabalenka have the mental game to hang in there?"

The 5'11" Belarussian, brimming with confidence, started with an ace